

A Zettelkasten primer

How small, linked notes turn reading into writing. A sample for the Kasten dev vault.

A Zettelkasten, or slip box, is a way of keeping notes so that they keep working after you write them. Each note is small, written in your own words and linked to the notes it belongs with. Over time the links, not the folders, become the structure of what you know.

1. One idea per note

A note should hold one idea, written in your own words, so that it can be understood without the context it came from. Small notes are easy to link, easy to move and easy to reuse in a new argument. When a note grows a second idea, split it in two and link the halves.

2. Link as you write

Every new note is placed next to the notes it belongs with. Ask which existing note it continues, contradicts or supports, and link it there. Links are cheaper than folders: a note can sit in many conversations at once, and each link records why two ideas meet.

3. Let structure emerge

Do not design the structure before the notes exist. Clusters of densely linked notes become topics of their own, and an index note that points to the entry points of each cluster is enough to find your way back in. Structure is the result of the work, not its precondition.

4. From reading to writing

Highlight while you read, then turn the passages that matter into notes of your own. Keep the reference to the source with every note, so you can always return to the page an idea came from and read it again in context.

A highlight is not yet a note. It becomes one when you say, in a sentence of your own, why the passage matters and where it leads. That sentence is the start of the next note.

5. Review and revisit

Read old notes when you write new ones. A note you revisit gets better links and clearer wording, and ideas you had forgotten meet the ones you are working on today. The value of the box grows with the connections between its notes, not with their number.

Written for the Kasten sample vault. Select any passage to highlight it, then make it a card.